the time, people could only run email through the university system, and, back in Melbourne, I got involved in setting up a non-profit network and lobbying for deregulation of the Internet. It was a platform for setting up Suburbia Public Access Network, one of the first Internet Service Providers in Australia. We were ‘the free speech ISP’, and we made a point of hosting material others wouldn’t. You don’t get any thanks for that, but we fought for connectivity in the country and it came in the end. I continued to write code, most of which I released for free, culminating in Rubberhose.

Many of the early cryptographers, these inspired brain-iacs at Stanford or MIT who wanted to live in a world of pure maths and blue-sky thinking, were concerned about how to protect privacy. Everyone with a computer now takes it for granted, but the facts of authentication and key protection were established by guys working hard with little thanks: they knew that electronic mail and digital signatures and so on would depend on privacy, or else the Internet would become an enemy of free speech. Without security, people’s computer lives would be too easily monitored, controlled and abused. So this was the great issue and it was a matter, at that stage, of mathematics, the basis of cryptography.

As things got established with the Internet, I began to flow more naturally in that direction and I felt very strongly, as I still do, that you have to fight to organise and maintain freedom of intelligence. I wrote a posting in March 1996 appending an online advert for something called the Emailers Profit Centre, a ‘Multi-Level Marketing’ project that aimed to sell millions of email addresses to commercial companies. ‘Who wants to take this site down first?’ I wrote to fellow cypherpunks. This was the kind of challenge we were facing back then: how to stop the Net from simply becoming a vast tool for giant companies and governments to exploit people. Or for the security state to keep an eye on us. I loathe these security types, the types who point out that ‘Everything which is not explicitly permitted is denied.’ Who do they think they are, or, more to the point, who do they think we are? They are security fascists who would mobilise technology to secure their brutal vision. They are types whose idea of Nirvana is to maintain a cyberspace status quo in which the laws of physics have been rewritten so it is not possible for you to shift your chair without written authority. No longer a case simply of Big Brother watching you, but of Big Brother controlling your fingers, the movement of your mind, and keeping you from finding the world and its information on your own terms.